

Portfolio Review

Presenting the finished site, the design system, and the evidence behind it



The Week 12 question

You have built and revised a site for eleven weeks. Can you show, not just tell, what you decided and why?

Why it matters: a portfolio review rewards evidence over description. Every claim on screen should be checkable against the live site.

Verification: before presenting, test each claim yourself — open the live site and confirm it still holds.

Evidence to record: claim made, site checked, and what you found.

From building to presenting

Weeks 1 to 11 built the site. Week 12 is the last skill: turning that work into a legible, evidenced account of it.

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Learning outcomes

Present a site's purpose and structure, show its design system as artefacts, present evidence of testing and revision, and receive critique without becoming defensive.

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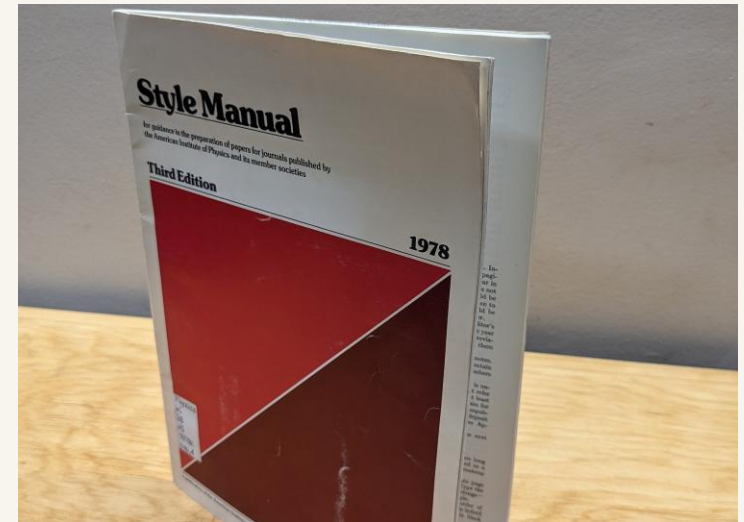
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Recap: Assignment 4

The process dossier asks for an information map, a design system reference, testing evidence, a change log and a critical reflection — this week rehearses presenting all five out loud.

Observe the visual, then connect it to the principle on this slide.



What a portfolio review actually assesses

Purpose, audience, IA

Who is this for, and what task does the sitemap support?

Visual system, responsive

Tokens shown as a sheet; behaviour shown by resizing live.

Accessibility, technical care

Keyboard task and one real DevTools fix, not a compliance claim.

Testing and revision

One obstacle named, one revision shown, with evidence.

Criterion 1: purpose, audience, IA

Can you say who the site is for, what task they come to do, and show the sitemap that supports that task in two clicks or fewer?

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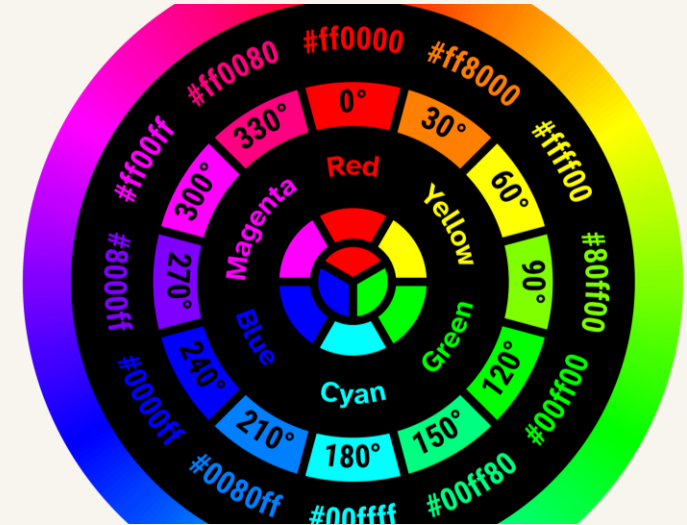
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Criterion 2: visual system, responsive

Can you show the type scale and colour tokens as a reference sheet, then resize the browser live and explain what changes and why?

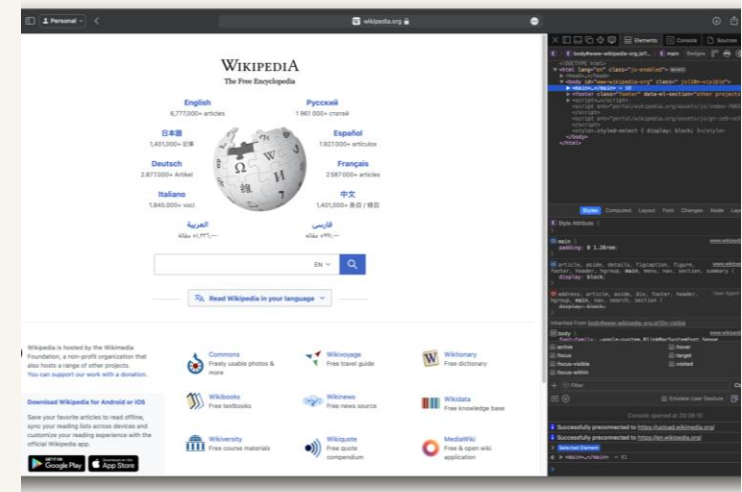
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Criterion 3: accessibility and technical care

Can you tab through a key task with a keyboard only, and show one real accessibility fix you made in DevTools, not just claim WCAG compliance?

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Criterion 4: testing and revision

Can you name one thing a real user got stuck on, and show the specific change you made in response, with a before-and-after?

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Structuring a design walkthrough

1. Problem, audience

Open with who and why, not the homepage.

2. IA

Sitemap or content model, visible next.

3. Visual system

Tokens as a reference sheet.

4. Live demo, evidence

One task, one obstacle, one fix.

Step 1: problem and audience first

Recap Week 1: content before interface. Open with who the site serves and what they need, not with the homepage screenshot.

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Step 2: information architecture

Recap Week 9: show the sitemap or content model next. A visitor's mental map should be visible before any visual design appears.

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Step 3: the visual system

Recap Week 3 (type scale) and Week 5 (colour and image system). Show the actual tokens, not adjectives like "modern" — a swatch grid, a type-scale ladder and a spacing ramp are checkable against the live site; a description is not.

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A design system slide, concretely

```
<style>
:root{
  --step-0: 1rem;
  --step-1: 1.25rem;
  --step-2: 1.563rem;
  --brand-ink: #18212A;
  --brand-accent: #C7831A;
  --space-3: 1.5rem;
}
</style>
```

Read this as a rule for what a review must show, not as markup to memorise.

Step 4: a live interaction demo

Recap Week 7. Do not describe the contact form — open it live, submit an empty field, and show the real error message and focus behaviour.

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Step 5: evidence, not claims

Recap Week 1 (reflection and evidence) and Week 10 (user testing). "It went well" is a claim. An observed blocker plus the fix that followed is evidence.

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Worked example: blocker to revision

Observed: a tester tried to tap a 20px icon-only nav link and missed twice.
Revision: enlarged the tap target to 44px and added a visible text label.
Recap Week 10's method: group raw session notes into named obstacles before the review, not during it.

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The change log as a presentable artefact

A dated table turns a semester of small decisions into a legible record a reviewer can scan in under a minute.

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Change log worked example

```
<table>
<tr><th>Date</th><th>Change</th><th>Why</th><th>Evidence</th></tr>
<tr><td>Wk 6</td><td>Added breakpoint</td><td>Nav overlapped at 375px</td><td>Screenshot, device test</td></tr>
<tr><td>Wk 10</td><td>Enlarged tap target</td><td>User missed nav link twice</td><td>Session recording</td></tr>
</table>
```

Read this as a rule for what a review must show, not as markup to memorise.

Handling critique in the room

Recap Week 1's critique method: evidence before preference. A reviewer's opinion is a starting point, not a verdict, until tested against a task. Write the comment down before responding, and ask what task or expectation produced it before explaining your reasoning.

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A clarifying question to keep ready

"What were you trying to do when that happened?" turns a vague complaint into a specific, checkable usability observation.

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Live and technical walkthrough checklist

Some things must be shown live. Others can be described. Confusing the two is the most common portfolio-review mistake.

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Demonstrate live vs describe

Show live: keyboard-only navigation of one task, a resize across a breakpoint, one DevTools accessibility fix.

Describe: hosting choices, asset pipeline, file naming.

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Common failure modes

All screenshots, no site

A review that never opens the live URL invites doubt about what actually works.

Vague reflection

"I learned a lot" is not evidence. Name the obstacle and the specific change.

Design system not in the site

Tokens on a slide that don't match the shipped CSS undercut the whole walkthrough.

Critique met with defence

Arguing with feedback instead of testing it reads as unprepared, not confident.

Self-assessment against the rubric

Score your own project against all four criteria before presenting. A worked example, scored honestly, with the evidence for each score.

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Worked self-assessment example

IA: strong, sitemap tested with two users. Visual system: solid, tokens documented. Accessibility: partial, colour contrast unchecked on one page. Testing: strong, three sessions logged. A gap you find yourself is a fixable footnote; a gap a reviewer finds first is a credibility problem — score honestly, then patch the weakest area.

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Testable review checklist

Purpose and audience stated first. IA shown before visuals. Design system shown as a reference sheet. One live interaction demonstrated. One observed blocker paired with its fix. Change log dated. Self-assessed against all four criteria.

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Further practice

Nielsen Norman Group's articles on portfolio and design critique, and the course's own Assignment 4 brief and rubric, support continued preparation.

Closing studio task

Prepare a five-minute walkthrough of a work-in-progress project: problem and audience, IA, visual system, one live interaction, one piece of testing evidence, and a one-sentence reflection. Deliver it in the final session.

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